

Are children moral creatures?

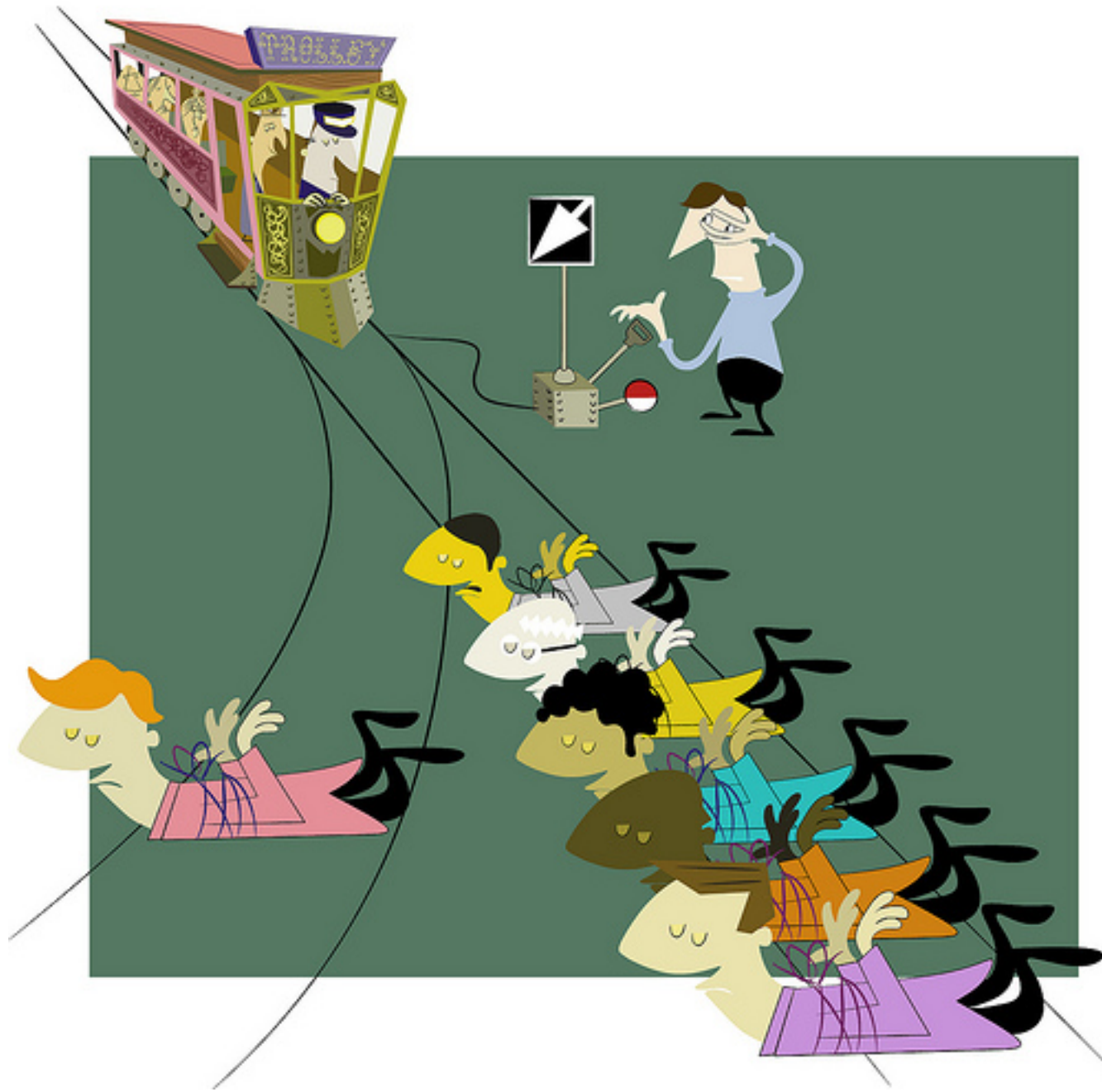


T/Th 9:35-10:25am

Professor Casey Lew-Williams

Kennedy Casey, Abby Fergus, Sarah Joo, Chantal Valdivia, Claire Whiting

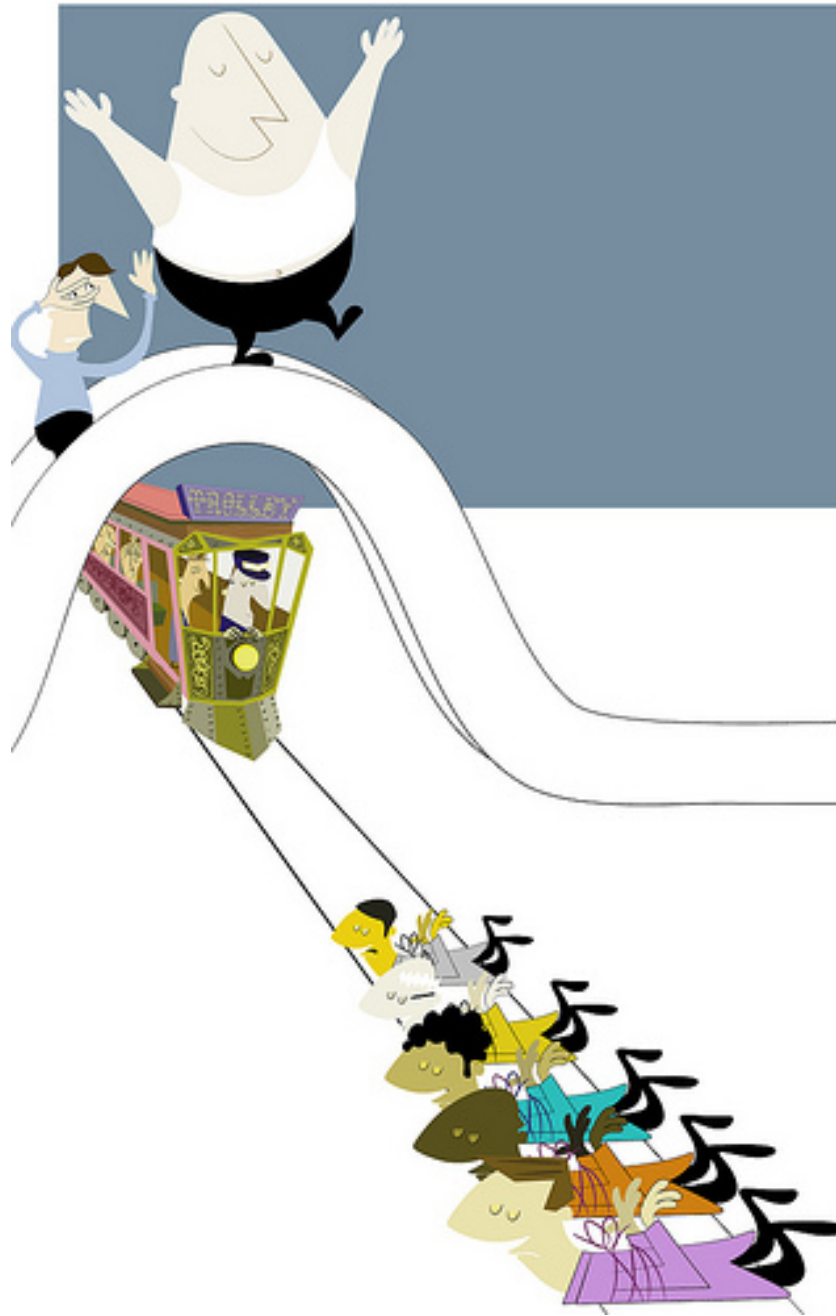




Trolley Problem: should you pull the lever?

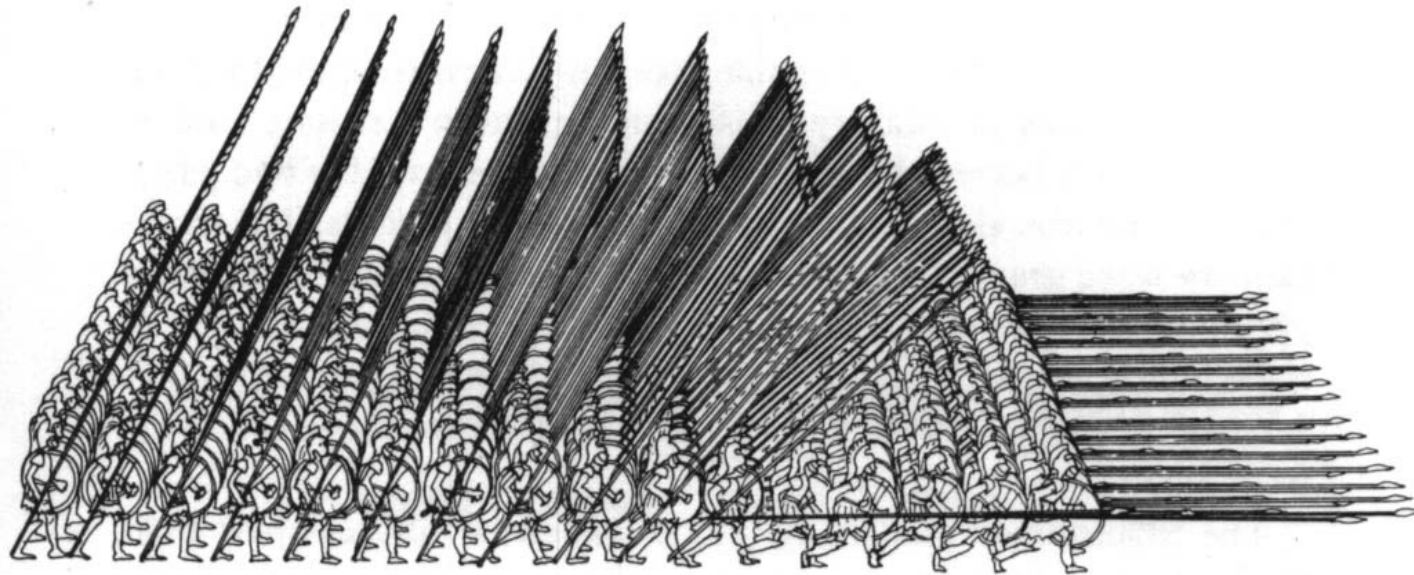
A 2-year-old's solution to the Trolley Problem





Should you push this guy off the bridge?

Historical perspective: **Darwin**



The Macedonian phalanx, here shown in its fighting formation of 256 men, the syntagma.

*A tribe including many members who, from possessing in a high degree the spirit of patriotism, fidelity, obedience, courage, and sympathy, were always ready to aid one another, and to sacrifice themselves for the common good, would be victorious over most other tribes; and this would be natural selection. **At all times throughout the world tribes have supplanted other tribes; and ... morality is one important element in their success.***

Historical perspective: **Piaget**

- Piaget and Kohlberg were “rationalists”
- Explicit reasoning provides the foundations of moral judgments



Historical perspective: **Piaget**

Story 1. A little boy named John is in his room. He is called to dinner. He goes into the dining room. But, behind the door there was a chair, and on the chair there was a tray with 15 cups on it. John couldn't have known that there was all this behind the door. He goes in, the door knocks against the tray, and bang go the 15 cups, and they all get broken!

Story 2. Once there was a little boy named Henry. One day when his mother was out, he tried to get some cookies out of the cupboard. He climbed up on the chair and stretched out his arm. But the cookie jar was too high and he couldn't reach it. While he was trying to get it he knocked over a cup. The cup fell down and broke.

Historical perspective: **Piaget**

- **Stage 1** (before 7-8 years of age)

- Moral realism
- Objective responsibility
- Punishment for its own sake
- Immanent justice

Transitional stage (around 7-10 years)

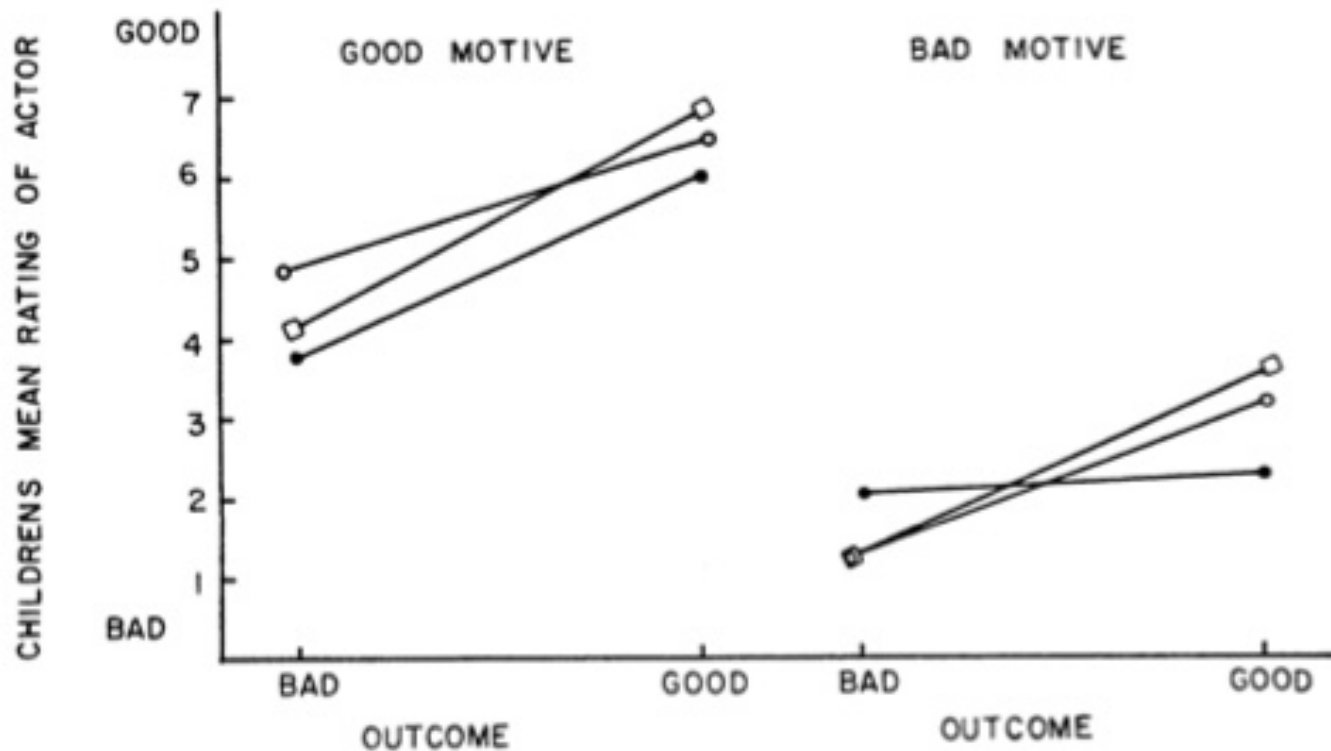
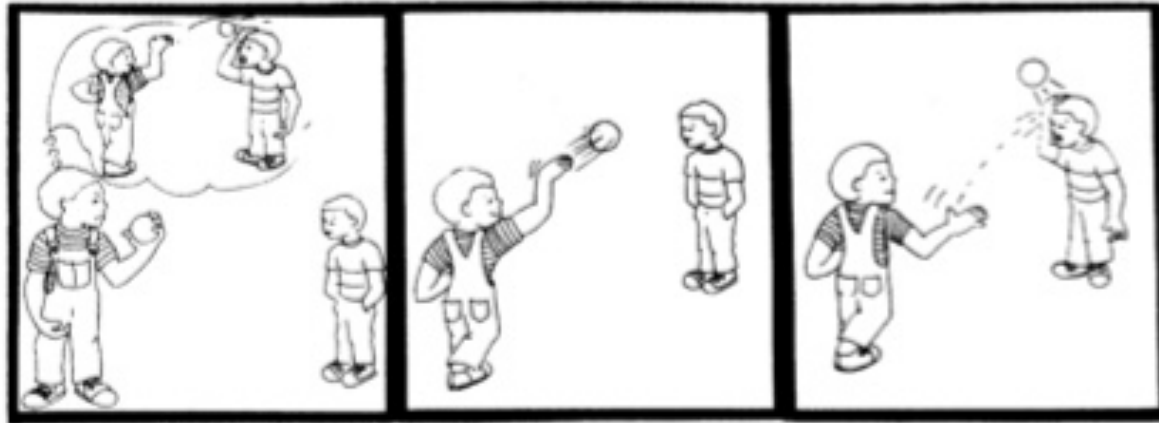
- More interactions with peers
- Start to value fairness and equality
- Become more autonomous in their thinking

- **Stage 2** (around 11-12 years)

- Rules are arbitrary
- Intent > objective consequences
- Punishment should fit the crime

Historical perspective: **Piaget**

- But young children *can* consider others' intentions



Historical perspective: **Kohlberg**

Heinz's wife is dying from an illness. A drug that might save her has been discovered by a local pharmacist, but he was charging 10 times what it took him to make it. This was far more money than Heinz had. So Heinz went to everyone he knew to borrow the money, but he could only get together about half the price. He told the pharmacist that his wife was dying and asked for a discount, or if he could pay the rest later. But, the pharmacist said, "No, I discovered the drug and I'm going to make money from it". So, Heinz got desperate and broke into the store to steal the drug for his wife.

Should Heinz have done that? Why?

Historical perspective: **Kohlberg**

- Preconventional, Stage 1

- Obedience to authority, fear of punishment

Pro-stealing: *“If you let your wife die, you will get in trouble”*

Con: *“You shouldn’t steal because you could go to jail”*

- Preconventional, Stage 2

- What is right is what’s in one’s own best interest
- Might involve equal exchange between people

Pro: *“He can always pay him back”*

Con: *“The druggist just wants to make a profit like others*

Historical perspective: **Kohlberg**

- Conventional, Stage 3

- Moral behavior is that which helps or is approved by others
- Primary objective is to be thought of as 'good'

Pro: "No one will think you are bad if you steal the drug, but your family will think you are inhuman if you don't"

Con: "If you steal, you might bring dishonor on your family; you won't be able to face anyone."

- Conventional, Stage 4

- What is right is upholding laws & contributing to group/society
- Kids don't fear punishment, but believe rules & laws maintain order

Pro: "The druggist is leading the wrong kind of life if he lets someone die, so Heinz had to steal... but he must pay the druggist back and accept punishment"

Con: "Natural to want to steal, but you have to follow the rules regardless of your personal feelings"

Historical perspective: **Kohlberg**

- Postconventional, Stage 5

- Laws express the will of the majority and further human values
- Laws that compromise rights might be challenged

Pro: "Heinz should steal the drug because the right to life supersedes or transcends the right to property"

- Postconventional, Stage 6

- Hold abstract moral guidelines of universal justice (and respect for all human beings) that transcend any law or social contract that may conflict with them.
- For Kohlberg, this was an ideal state.
- Few people get categorized at this level.

Historical perspective: **Haidt**

“Moral dumbfounding”

Example scenario:

Julie and Mark are brother and sister. They are traveling together in France on summer vacation from college. One night they are staying alone in a cabin near the beach. They decide that it would be interesting and fun if they tried having sex. At the very least it would be a new experience for each of them. Julie was already taking birth control pills, but Mark uses a condom too, just to be safe. They both enjoy it, but they decide not to do it again. They keep that night as a special secret, which makes them feel even closer to each other. What do you think about that? Was it okay to have sex?

Historical perspective: **Haidt**

Hypothetical Experimenter: **Is it OK?**

Hypothetical Participant: No, not ok.

Why?

Wellll, it's incest and that's bad, it leads to birth defects.

But they're using two kinds of contraceptives – is it still wrong if there isn't a baby?

Yeah.

Why?

Well, it would be kinda bad for the rest of the family.

But they don't tell anyone.

I don't know. I can't really explain it. But I just know it's wrong.

...

“uhh... this is hard.... I mean, there's no way I'd change my mind. I just don't know how to say what I'm feeling. It's crazy.”

Historical perspective: **Haidt**

- “Intuitionist” theory
 - Moral judgment is caused by quick moral intuitions, often based on emotions.
 - Moral emotions depend on encapsulated, evolved systems; we may experience them without understanding their causes.
 - Moral judgments is followed by slow *ex post facto* moral reasoning (of the sort Piaget & Kohlberg studied)

Historical perspective: Haidt's 5 moral foundations

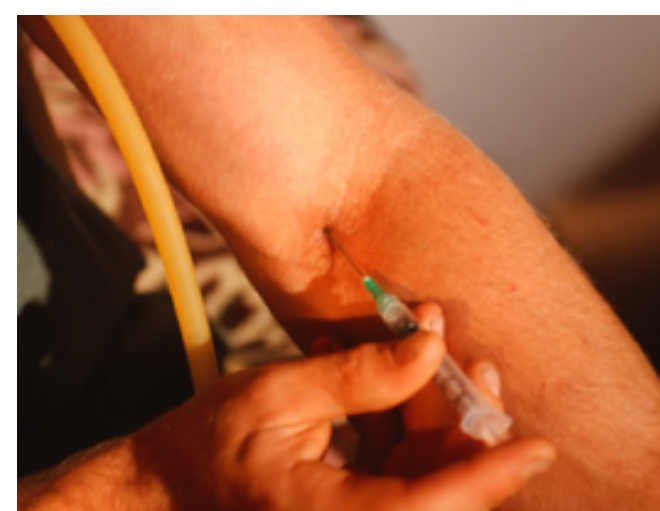
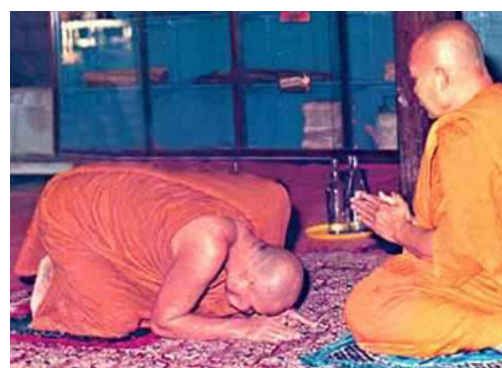
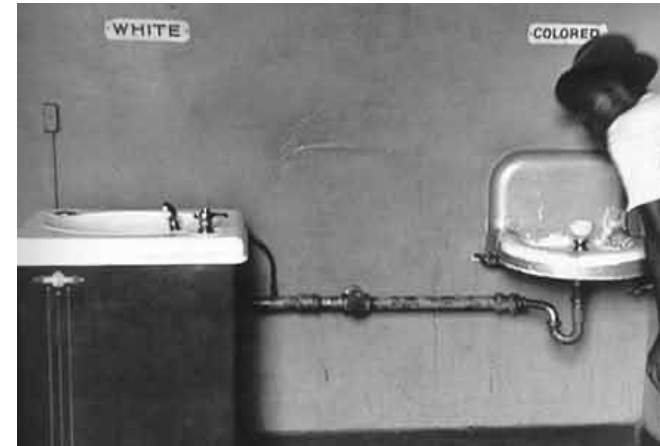
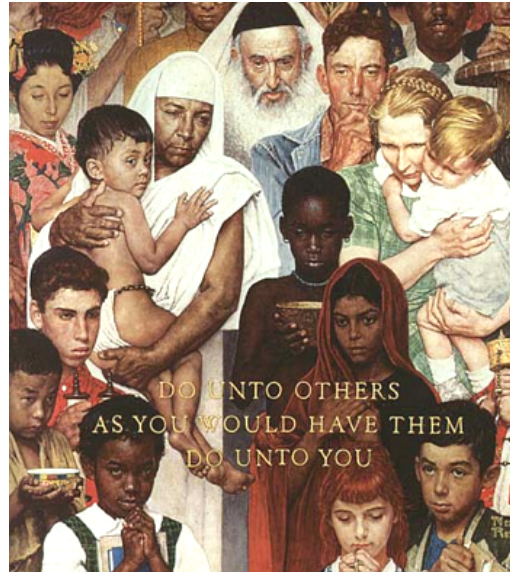
1) care/harm

2) fairness/cheating

3) loyalty/betrayal

4) authority/subversion

5) purity/sanctity



Historical perspective: Haidt's 5 moral foundations

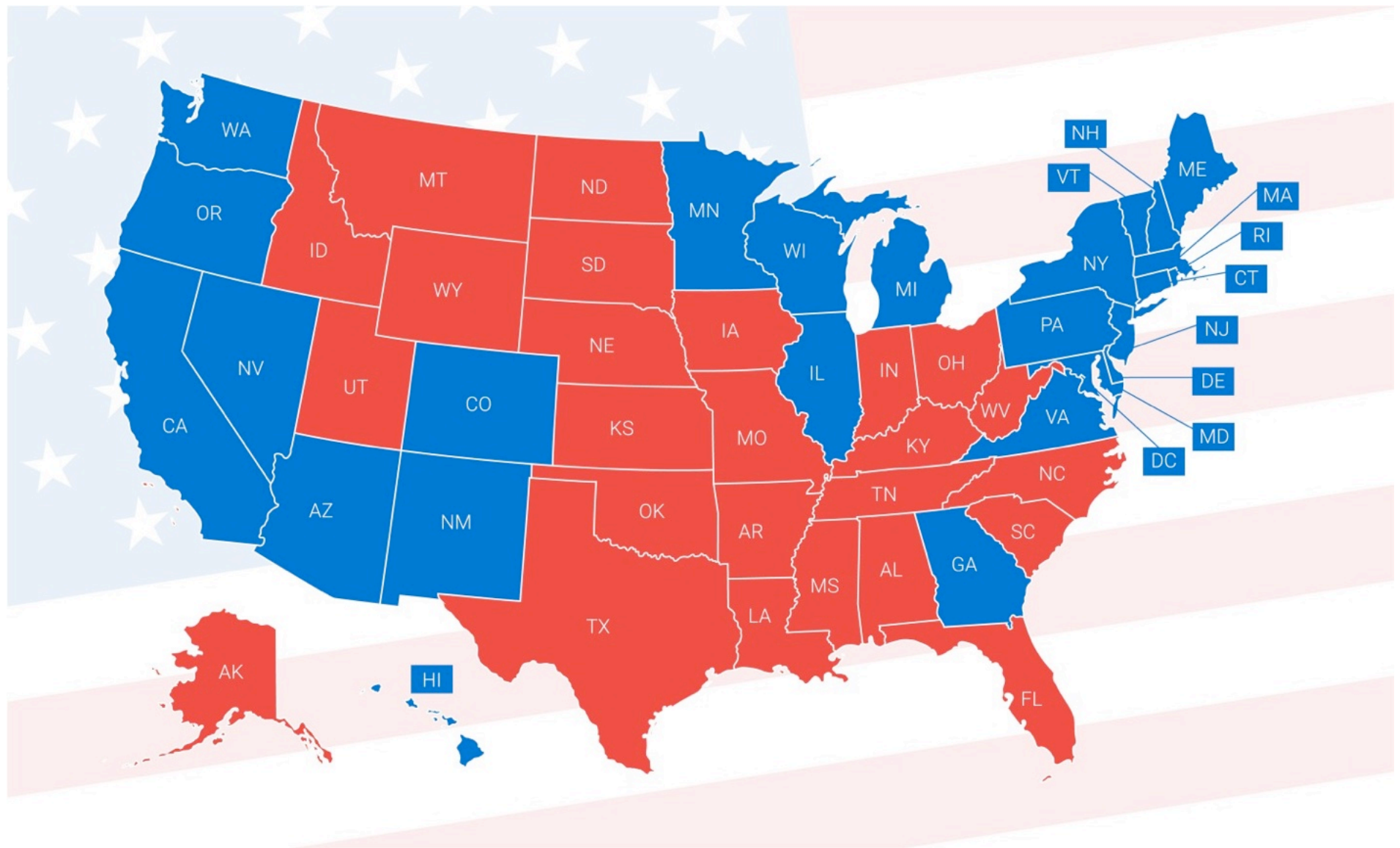
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Historical perspective: Haidt's 5 moral foundations

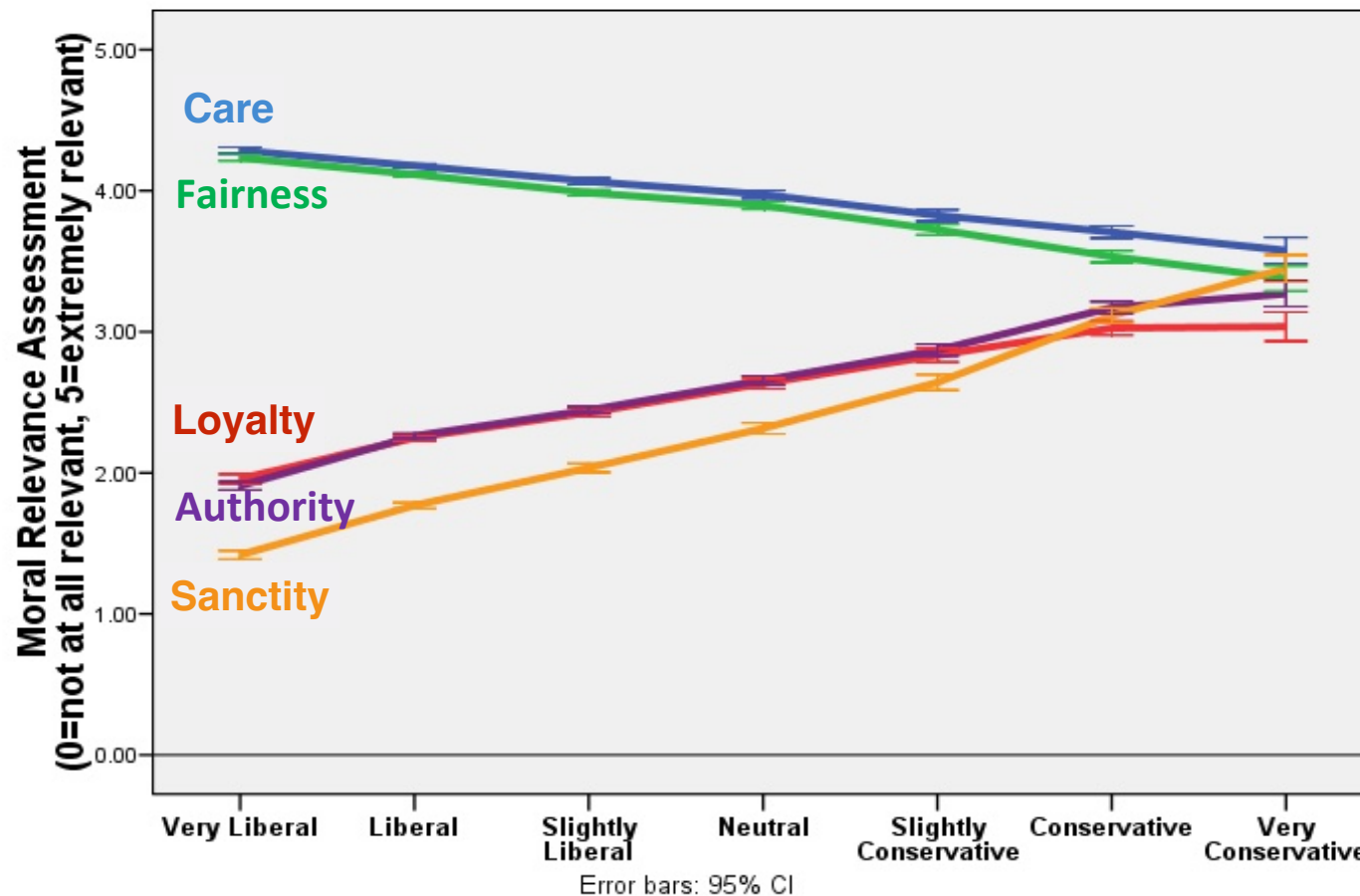
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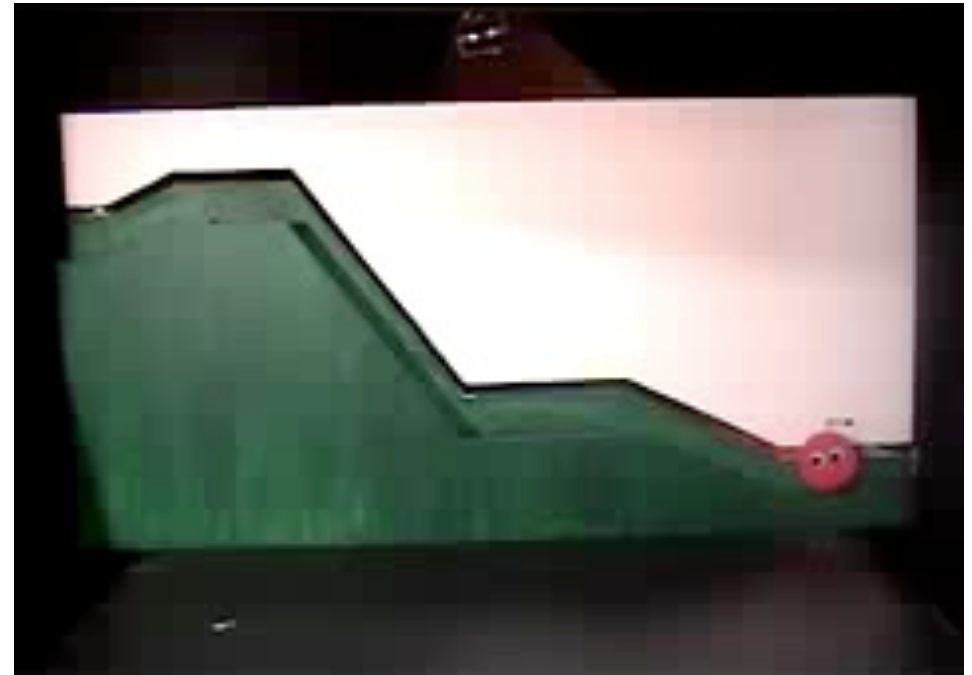
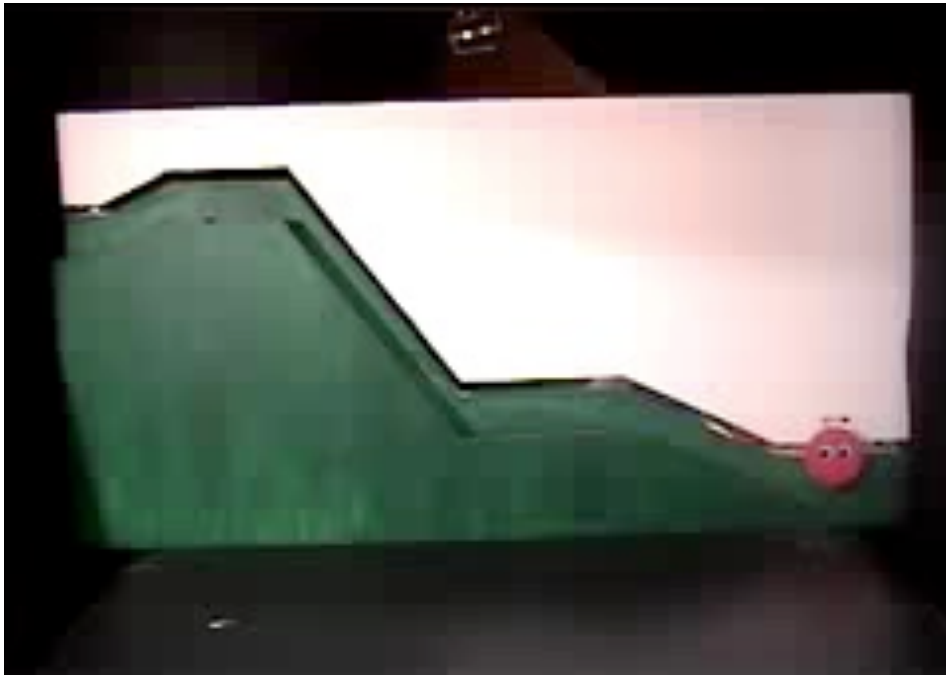


A possible 6th moral foundation, according to Haidt: **liberty/oppression**

Experiments on the development of morality

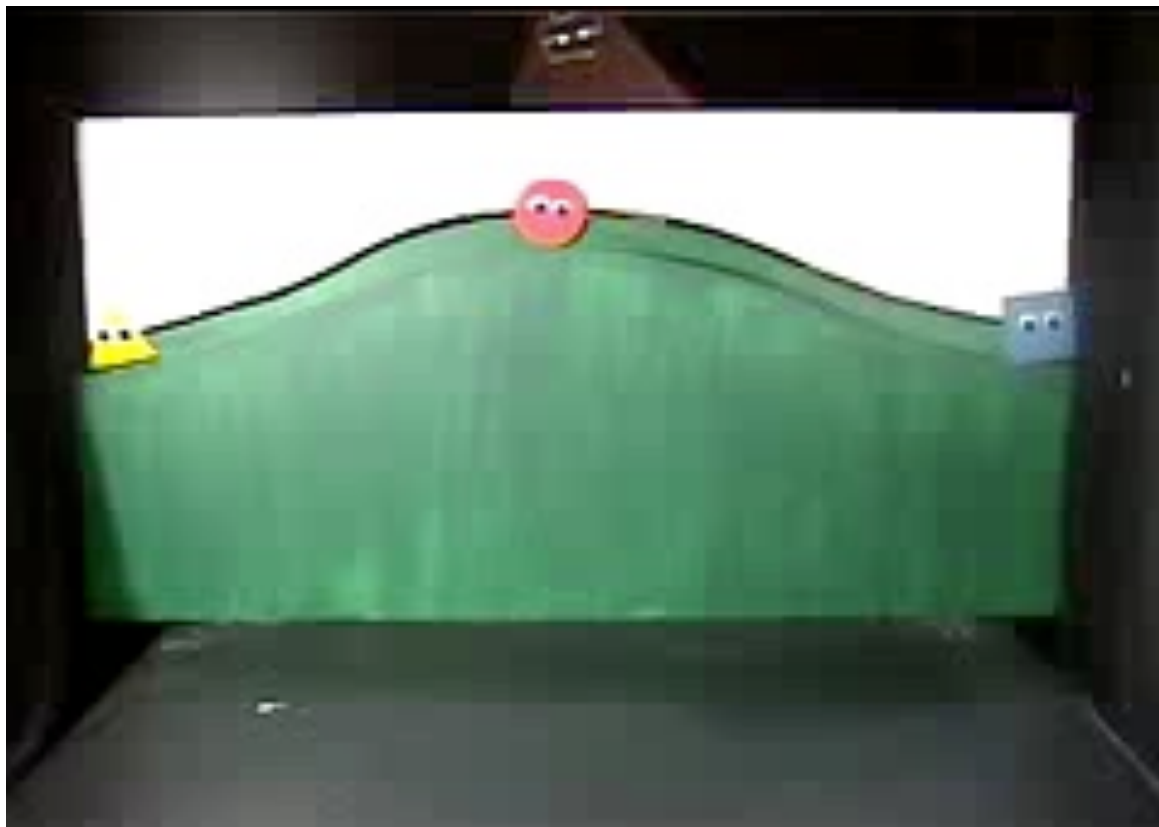
Harm/care in infancy

- Do babies use others' harmful or helpful actions to guide own preference for individuals?



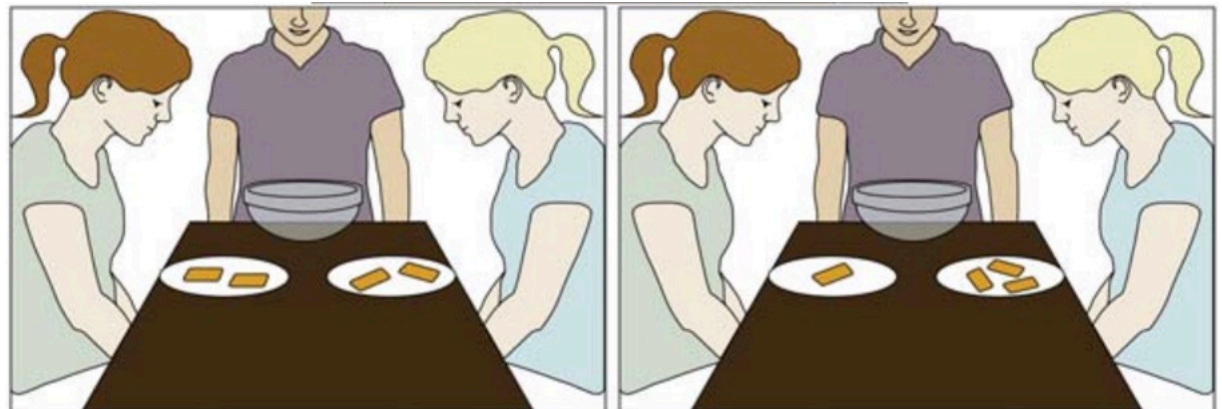
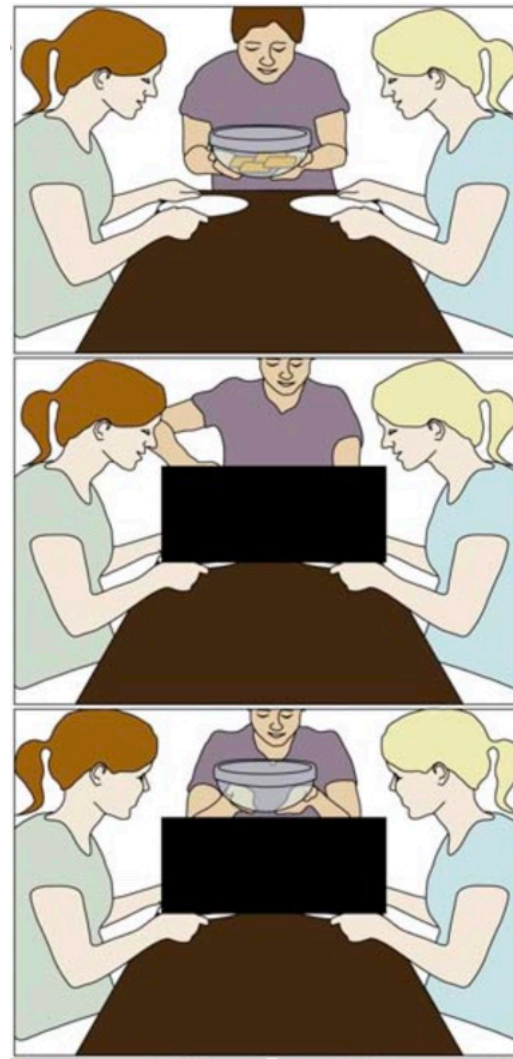
Harm/care in infancy

- Do babies use others' harmful or helpful actions to guide their expectations about actions?



Fairness in infancy

- Do infants care about fairness?



Fairness in childhood

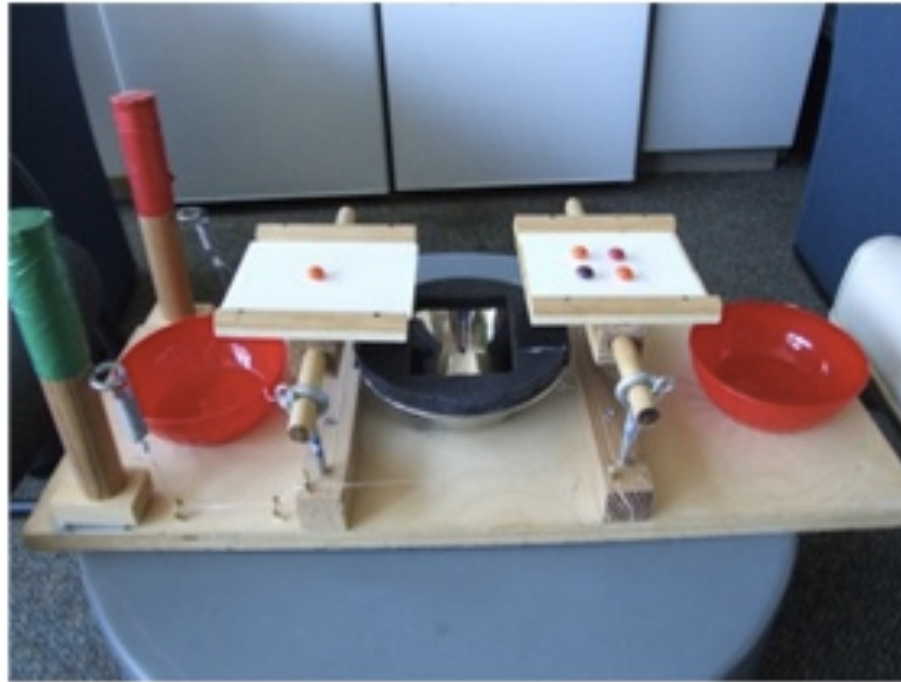


**It's not
fair!!!**

Fairness in childhood

- Are children averse to inequity?

Decider



Recipient

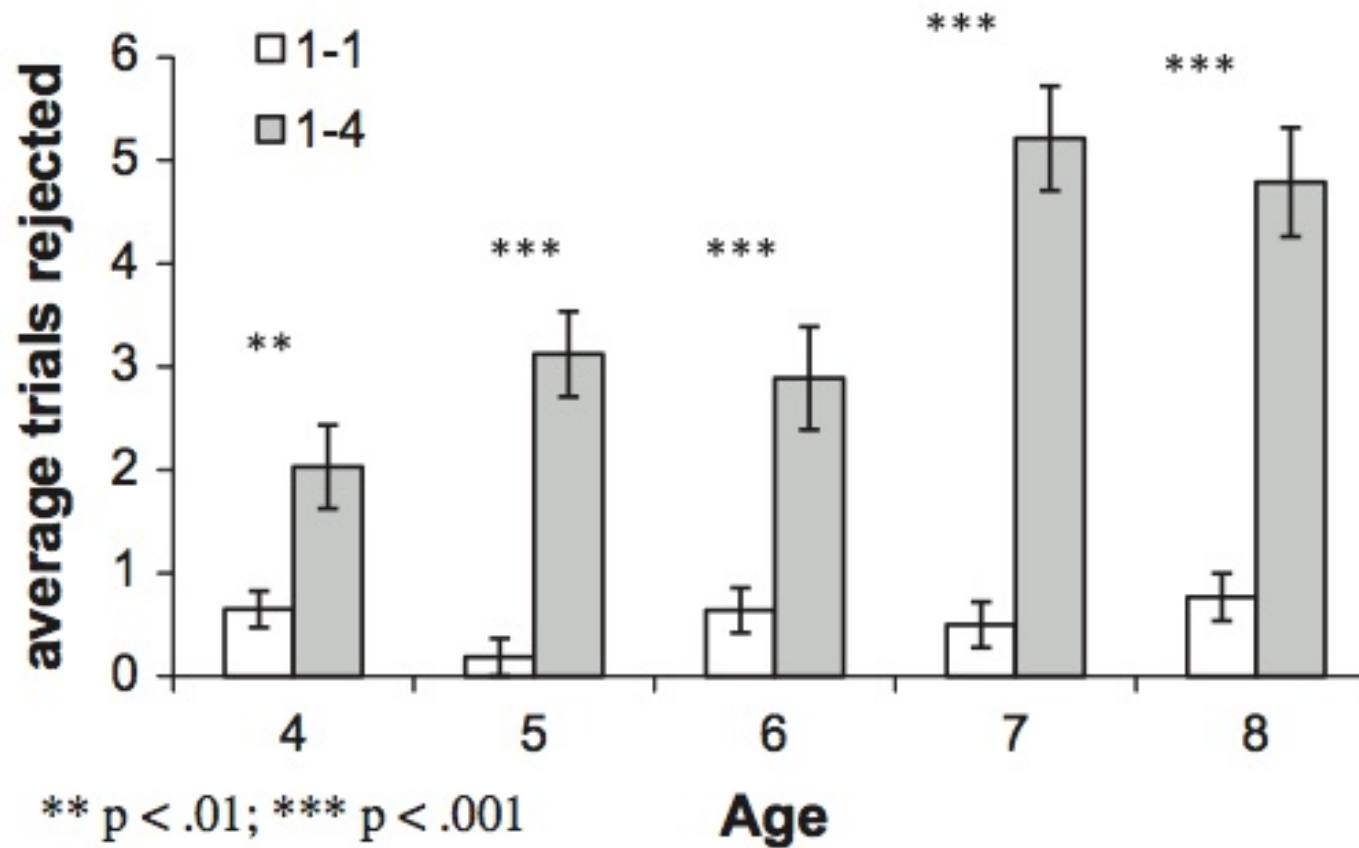
- **Two conditions:**
 - (1) “Disadvantageous Inequity”
 - 1 for decider, 4 for recipient
 - or 1 for decider, 1 for recipient
 - (2) “Advantageous Inequity”
 - 4 for decider, 1 for recipient
 - or 1 for decider, 1 for recipient

Fairness in childhood



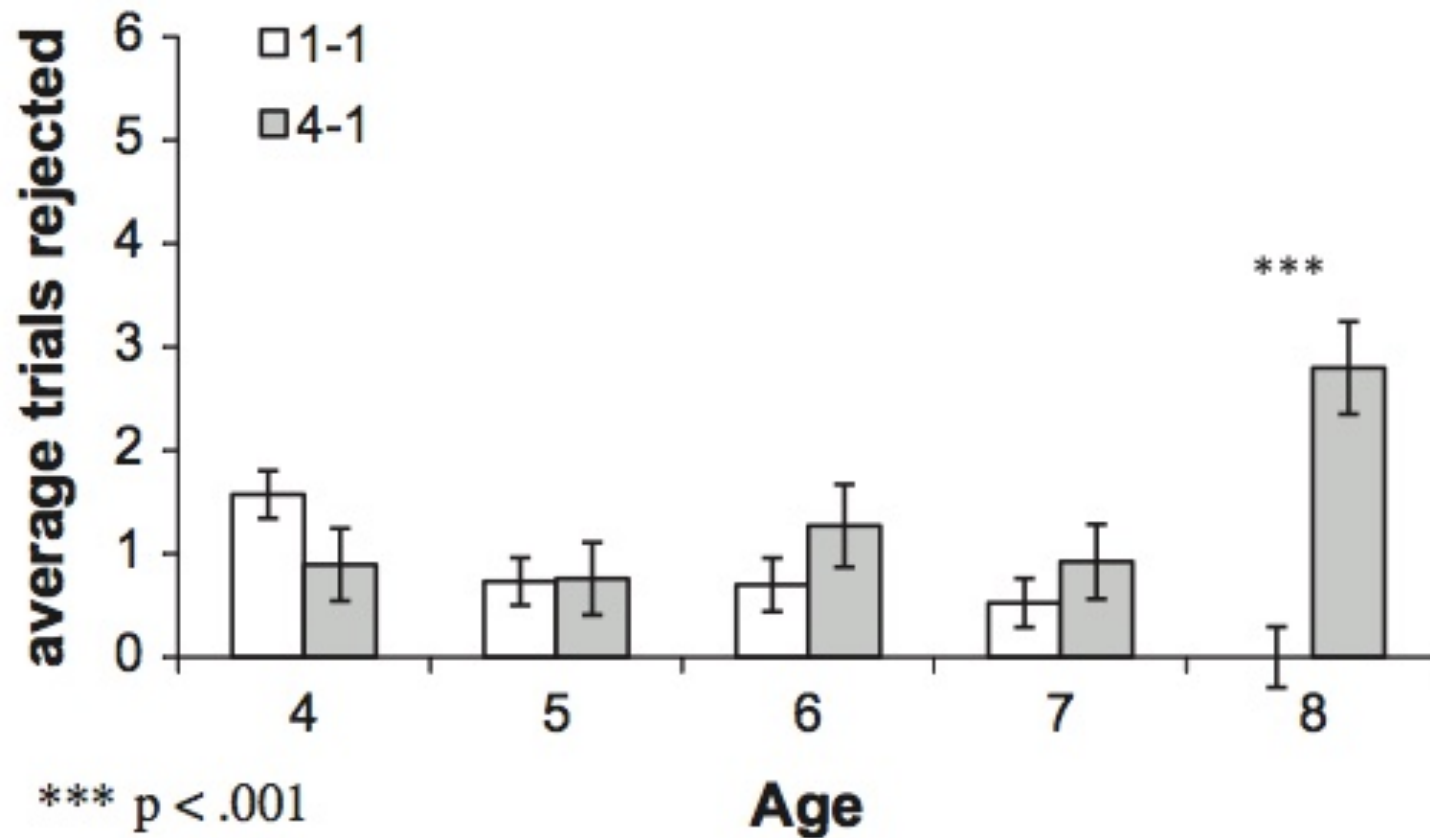
Fairness in childhood

- Results for Disadvantageous Inequity



Fairness in childhood

- Results for Advantageous Inequity



Fairness in childhood

- Children are more likely to cheat when they benefit together (vs. alone) (Abuova et al., 2025)
- Children are more likely to cheat when adults aren't watching
 - “Study 1 ($N = 150$) demonstrated that children cheated least when an adult was visible (6%), moderately when only audible (20%), and the most when neither visible nor audible (48%). Study 2 ($N = 150$) revealed that this effect was driven by whether the adult could readily observe children's cheating, rather than by her mere presence. Studies 3 and 4 ($N = 50$ each) further showed that children strategically adjusted their behavior based on how readily their cheating could be detected.” (Zhao, Yang, & Zheng, 2025)

Loyalty in childhood

- Children share more
 - with parents than with strangers
 - with friends than with strangers
 - own-gender & own-race? (next lecture...)

Authority/respect in childhood

- Children put more trust in people who receive social attention.



Relevance to budding political views

- Are kids who use 'intrinsic' explanations (e.g., about why some people are in poverty) more likely to be conservative?



Relevance to budding political views

- Does parents' political ideology shape how children punish outgroup and ingroup members?

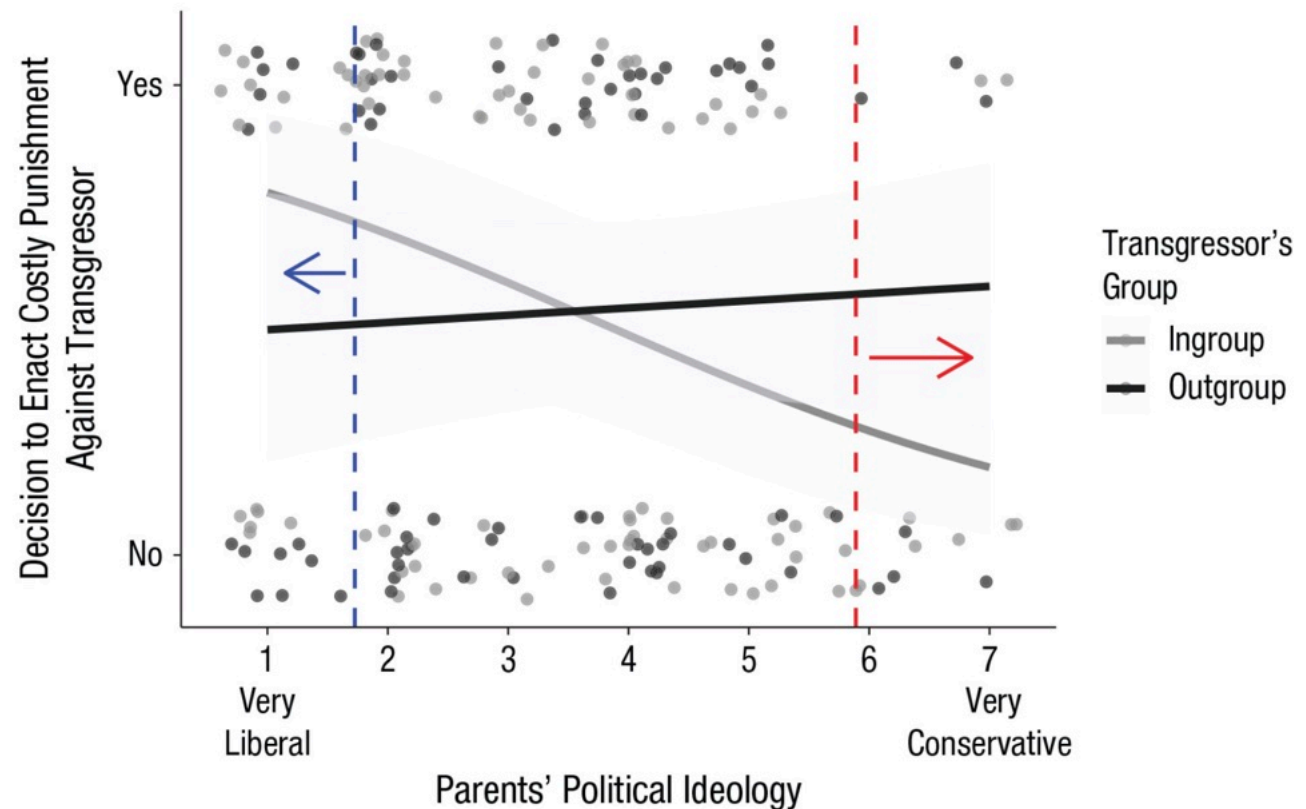


Fig. 5. Predicted values for the interaction between group and parents' political ideology on children's costly punishment decisions in Experiment 2, accounting for children's age. Small circles represent responses of individual participants. Dotted vertical lines represent the points on the political ideology scale at which punishment of in-group and out-group transgressors diverged ($p < .05$). Error bands indicate 95% confidence intervals.



Parenting advice can drive you crazy

How to be a parent:

Make sure your children's academic, emotional, psychological, mental, athletic, spiritual, physical, nutritional, and social needs are met while being careful not to overstimulate, understimulate, improperly medicate, helicopter, or neglect them in a screen-free, processed food-free, GMO-free, negative energy-free, plastic-free, body positive, socially and environmentally conscious, egalitarian but also authoritative, nurturing but independence-minded, gentle but not permissive, pesticide-free, two-story, multilingual home, with carefully curated exposure to music and politics, in a safe neighborhood featuring native plant species and tall trees, with neither too much nor too little distance from extended family, preferably in a quiet cul-de-sac just three blocks away from urban cultural centers, with a backyard, a dog or cat, and 1.5 siblings.

How to be a parent in every prior generation:

Feed them sometimes I guess?

A lovely book on parenting

